

SCROLL, CLICK, TRAP

WHY YOUNG INDIANS ARE PRIME TARGETS FOR CYBERCRIME

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India's youth is plugged into smartphones; from entertainment and social connections to financial services, all their needs are served by their mobile device. But with the growing connectivity comes the real danger. Cyberthreats are now targeting young mobile users with scale and sophistication, and their mobile devices is the origin of these attacks.

The recent Comprehensive Annual Modular Survey (CAMS) highlights that nearly 97% of Indians of the age group 15-24 own mobile phones and are present online. This number is far outpacing older age groups and indicates that the everyday life of the youth is now mobile-first.

Is our youth cyber aware?

The rapid adoption of e-commerce, online banking, and social media has increased convenience but also heightened cyber risks for young users. Many share personal data, reuse passwords, and rely heavily on smartphones for payments, often without adequate cybersecurity awareness or safe digital practices, making them easy targets for fraud.

Scams and frauds

Cybercriminals are exploiting everyday tools such as WhatsApp, Telegram, and Reddit to target youngsters. Fraudsters have been luring young people to install malicious APKs that drain bank accounts and hijack devices, leading to loss of personal information as well as financial credentials. We witnessed a case where a 19-year-old lost ₹1.6 lakh after downloading a fake "PM Kishan Yojana" app sent via WhatsApp.

Even online games are now being exploited through fake cheat codes



that lure children into clicking malicious links, leading to fraud, data theft, and even digital blackmail.

Scams have become detailed and are engineered to look exactly like trusted platforms. Hackers combine psychological manipulations such as honey traps, lures via phishing links, and even impersonation to target young users.

Growing malware threats

Smartphones are also gateways for malware and malicious applications. Through phishing links, fake downloads, and social engineering tactics, malicious apps are shared, often disguised as games, filters, or study tools. Once installed, they can access private chats, photos, contacts, and even intercept messages.

Cyberbullying, sextortion, and psychological risks

Beyond financial fraud, India is seeing a sharp rise in sextortion and cyberbullying, where private content is weaponized for blackmail and

reputational harm. Maharashtra alone reported losses of ₹21 crore between 2022 and 2025. These crimes inflict deep psychological trauma, yet awareness and response mechanisms remain weak. This reality is starkly reflected in Netflix's *Adolescence*, which portrays how unsupervised internet access can expose children to manipulation, exploitation, and emotional harm, often without parents realizing the risks.

Lack of cybersafety habits

Despite rising digital engagement among young Indians, cybersecurity awareness remains worryingly low. The APAC Consumer Cybersecurity Survey reveals that only 25% of Indian internet users use security apps, most parents never discuss online safety with their children, and fewer than one in five people know how to report a cybercrime.

Although initiatives like CyberJagrit Bharat, the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal, and the 1930 helpline exist, usage remains limited.

Click safely, pay safely, talk safely

In this always-connected world, CYBX serves as a digital passport, carried everywhere to navigate the internet securely. It helps users detect phishing links, scan QR codes safely, and use protected calling to avoid fraud and impersonation. Much like oxygen sustains life, CYBX is becoming vital for a secure digital life. With built-in protection and mobile cybersecurity insurance of up to ₹10 lakh in CYBX embedded plans underwritten by ICICI Lombard GIC Ltd., it offers confidence, continuity, and peace of mind in an increasingly risky online ecosystem. ■